
Too Lean to Fly

Solving IndiGo's Pilot Inventory Crisis Through Safety Stock Optimization

Sri Vaishnavi Viswanathan

Department of Industrial & Systems Engineering, IIT Kharagpur

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Abstract

In December 2025, IndiGo Airlines cancelled over 5,000 flights in a single month due to a severe shortage of cockpit crew, triggered by the enforcement of revised Flight Duty Time Limitations (FDTL). This case study reframes IndiGo's workforce planning as an inventory management problem: pilots as stock units, cancellations as stock-outs, and hiring timelines as lead times. Through demand forecasting, stochastic uncertainty modeling, and service-level optimization, we find that an optimal workforce of **2,544 pilots** at a **99% service level**, carrying a safety stock of **459 pilots**, minimizes total annual cost at ₹1,345.75 crore. A reorder point of 234 pilots below target governs recruitment timing. The safety-stock investment of ₹239 crore/year would have prevented crisis losses exceeding ₹829 crore

Keywords: inventory management, safety stock, service level optimization, stochastic demand, airline operations, reorder point analysis

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1. Case Background

IndiGo (InterGlobe Aviation Ltd.) commands over 60% of India's domestic aviation market. Its business model rests on a single-type Airbus A320 fleet, 30-minute domestic turnarounds, and a hub-and-spoke network where one crew and one aircraft connect multiple destinations sequentially. This structure achieves 12 block-hours per aircraft per day versus an industry average of 10, but leaves almost no buffer for disruptions.

In late 2025, revised FDTL regulations came into force. Key changes included: mandatory weekly rest increased from 36 to 48 hours, stricter limits on night flights and landings, and vacation days no longer counting as mandatory rest. The net effect was a **28% reduction in monthly productive hours per pilot** (from 125 to 90 hours). Airlines were given nearly two years to prepare. While competitors like Air India doubled their pilot workforce ahead of the deadline, IndiGo's headcount was lower in 2025 than the prior year, as they not only slowed down pilot hiring but also increased the number of routes. Combined with seasonal demand peaks, aircraft groundings for software maintenance, and adverse weather, IndiGo's On-Time Performance (OTP) collapsed to 19.7%, and over 5,000 domestic flights were cancelled in December 2025.

This case applies inventory management theory to answer: **(i)** how many pilots should've IndiGo optimally employed at the time of the crisis; **(ii)** what service level minimises total cost; **(iii)** what is the optimal safety stock; and **(iv)** when should recruitment be triggered (reorder point).

2. Inventory Framework

Defining What Standard Inventory Terms Are In Context Of The Case:

Table 1: Inventory concept mapping

Inventory Concept	IndiGo Equivalent
Stock unit	Active licensed pilot
Safety stock	Standby/reserve pilots
Demand	Scheduled flights → pilot-hours required
Stockout	Flight cancellation (insufficient crew)
Perishable goods	Daily pilot duty window (expires each day)
Holding cost	Pilot salary (Captain + First Officer mix)
Stockout cost	Refunds, rebooking, brand damage per cancellation
Lead time	Pilot hiring and training duration
Reorder point	Workforce threshold triggering recruitment

Scope: Domestic operations only (the crisis was almost exclusively domestic).

IndiGo serves 141 destinations: **96** domestic (**68%** of daily flights).

Decision horizon: Planning in 2023 for 2024-2026 operations.

3. Demand Forecasting

3.1. Base Pilot Requirement

IndiGo operated approximately **2,300** total daily flights in 2025-26, of which 68% were domestic:

$$\bar{d} = 2,300 \times 0.68 \approx \mathbf{1,564 \text{ domestic flights/day}}$$

Assume average domestic flight duration is **2 hours**, with **2 pilots** per flight. Total pilot-hours required per month:

$$H_{\text{month}} = 1,564 \times 2 \times 2 \times 30 = \mathbf{187,680 \text{ pilot-hours/month}}$$

Post-FDTL, each pilot delivers **90** productive hours per month. Base requirement:

$$B = \frac{187,680}{90} = \mathbf{2,085 \text{ pilots}}$$

3.2. Seasonal Adjustment

Historical data shows a 15% schedule expansion during April-June and December-January (5 peak months).

Seasonal peak requirement: $2,085 \times 1.15 = \mathbf{2,398 \text{ pilots}}$.

Weighted monthly average over a full year (7 off-peak, 5 peak months):

$$\bar{B} = \frac{7 \times 2,085 + 5 \times 2,398}{12} \approx \mathbf{2,215 \text{ pilots}}$$

4. Uncertainty Quantification

Three independent sources of demand variability are identified.

Unplanned absences. Industry data suggests 3-6% daily crew unavailability at any given point of time ($\mu = 4\%$, $\sigma = 1.5\%$):

$$\sigma_{\text{abs}} = 2,215 \times 0.015 \approx \mathbf{33 \text{ pilots}}$$

Operational disruptions (weather, tech delays). On Time Performance variability implies 1-3% disruption impact ($\mu = 2\%$, $\sigma = 1\%$):

$$\sigma_{\text{ops}} = 2,215 \times 0.01 \approx \mathbf{22 \text{ pilots}}$$

Seasonal variability. Demand oscillates between 2,085 and 2,398 pilots. Using a uniform distribution approximation:

$$\sigma_{\text{seas}} \approx 2,215 \times \frac{0.15}{\sqrt{3}} \approx \mathbf{193 \text{ pilots}}$$

Assuming independence across all three sources:

$$\sigma_{\text{total}} = \sqrt{33^2 + 22^2 + 193^2} = \sqrt{38,822} \approx \mathbf{197 \text{ pilots}}$$

Seasonal variability dominates, accounting for 96% of total variance.

5. Cost Structure

Holding cost (pilot salaries). IndiGo's pilot mix is 55% Captains (avg. ₹75 lakh/yr) and 45% First Officers (avg. ₹24 lakh/yr):

$$c_h = 0.55 \times 75 + 0.45 \times 24 = 52.05 \text{ lakh/pilot/year}$$

Stockout cost (cancellations). Direct costs (refunds, rebooking): ₹5 lakh per cancellation; brand damage (customer churn): ₹10 lakh. Total:

$$c_s = 15 \text{ lakh per cancelled flight}$$

6. Service Level Optimization

6.1. Model

Demand is modelled as $D \sim \mathcal{N}(\bar{B}, \sigma_{\text{total}}^2)$. Safety stock and total workforce are:

$$SS = z_\alpha \cdot \sigma_{\text{total}}, \quad N(\alpha) = B + SS$$

where $z_\alpha = \Phi^{-1}(\alpha)$.

Expected monthly pilot shortage uses the unit normal loss function:

$$\mathbb{E}[\text{shortage}] = \sigma_{\text{total}} \cdot L(z_\alpha), \quad L(z) = \phi(z) - z[1 - \Phi(z)]$$

Each pilot shortage of S pilots translates to cancelled flights as:

$$\text{Cancellations/month} = \frac{S \times 90}{2 \times 2} = 22.5 \cdot S$$

Total annual cost to minimise:

$$\text{TC}(\alpha) = N(\alpha) \cdot c_h \cdot 12 + \sigma_{\text{total}} \cdot L(z_\alpha) \cdot 22.5 \cdot 12 \cdot c_s$$

6.2. Results

Table 2: Service level optimization - all monetary values in ₹ crore/year

SL (%)	z	SS	Pilots	HC	Cancel./y.	SC	TC
90	1.28	252	2,337	1,216.36	2,520	378.00	1,594.36
95	1.65	325	2,410	1,254.41	1,140	171.00	1,425.41
97	1.88	370	2,455	1,277.83	972	145.80	1,423.63
99	2.33	459	2,544	1,324.15	144	21.60	1,345.75
99.5	2.58	508	2,593	1,349.66	89	13.35	1,363.01

The optimal solution is **99% service level** ($z^* = 2.33$), yielding a minimum total cost of ₹1,345.75 crore/year with 2,544 pilots and a safety stock of 459 pilots. At 99.5%, total cost rises again as the marginal holding cost increase outweighs the diminishing stockout savings.

The implied safety stock ratio is $459/2,085 \approx 22\%$, consistent with post-crisis reports mandating standby crew levels of at least 15%.

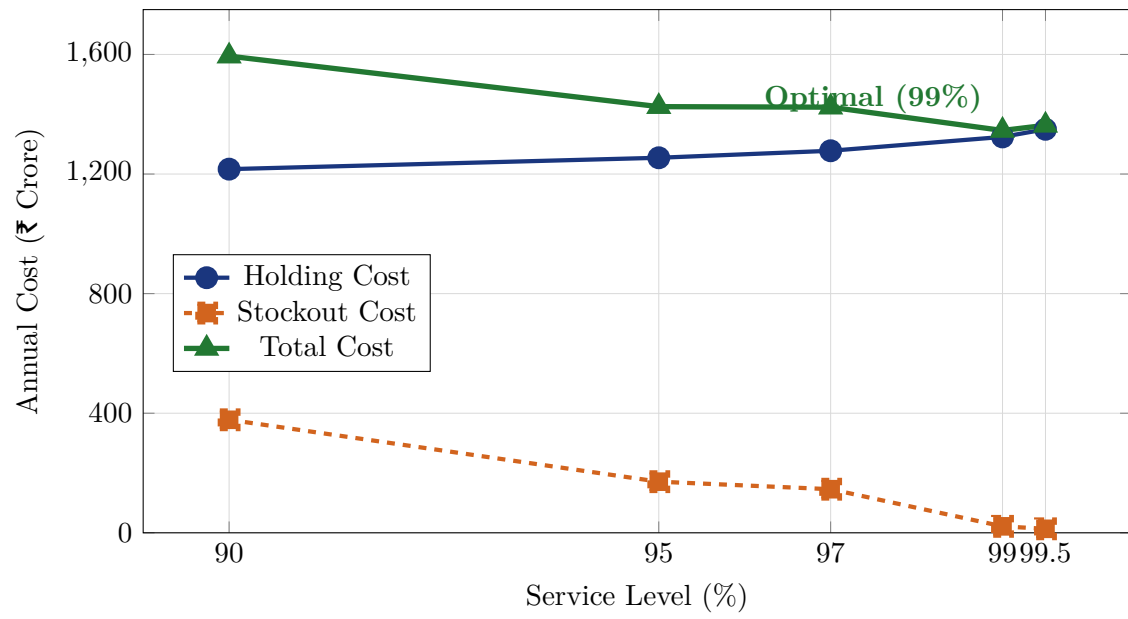


Figure 1: Service level vs. annual cost. Total cost is minimised at 99% service level.

7. Reorder Point Analysis

7.1. Lead Time

Pilot procurement follows two pathways: ab initio training (26 months, 60% of hires) and experienced pilot onboarding (3.5 months, 40% of hires). Weighted average lead time:

$$LT = 0.60 \times 26 + 0.40 \times 3.5 = \mathbf{17 \text{ months}}$$

7.2. Demand and Variability During Lead Time

Industry attrition is approximately 6%/year, giving a monthly attrition rate of 0.5%:

$$\bar{d} = 2,544 \times 0.005 \approx 13 \text{ pilots/month}$$

$$D_{LT} = 13 \times 17 = \mathbf{221 \text{ pilots}}$$

Standard deviation of monthly attrition demand ($\approx 10\%$ of mean): $\sigma_d = 1.3$ pilots/month. Over the lead time:

$$\sigma_{LT} = 1.3 \times \sqrt{17} \approx 5.36 \text{ pilots}$$

Safety stock during the lead time (at $z^* = 2.33$):

$$SS_{LT} = 2.33 \times 5.36 \approx \mathbf{13 \text{ pilots}}$$

7.3. Reorder Point

$$ROP = D_{LT} + SS_{LT} = 221 + 13 = \mathbf{234 \text{ pilots}}$$

Operational rule: When (active workforce) + (pilots in training pipeline) < $2,544 - 234 = 2,310$, IndiGo must initiate a new recruitment cycle immediately. With a 17-month lead time, this trigger needed to fire in early 2024 to ensure adequate staffing by late 2025.

8. Monte Carlo Simulation

8.1. Purpose

The analytical model derives safety stock and service levels from closed-form expressions under an assumed normal demand distribution. The simulation validates this: given the same $\mathcal{N}(2085, 197^2)$ demand model, does empirically observed stockout frequency across 10,000 simulated months converge to the theoretical service level? Agreement confirms the z-score and loss function calculations are internally consistent.

8.2. Method

Monthly pilot demand is sampled as:

$$D_t \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu = 2,085, \sigma^2 = 197^2), \quad t = 1, \dots, 10,000$$

A stockout occurs whenever $D_t > N(\alpha)$, i.e. demand exceeds the employed headcount. The empirical service level is:

$$\hat{\alpha} = 1 - \frac{\#\{t : D_t > N(\alpha)\}}{10,000}$$

This is repeated for all five candidate service levels. The average shortfall per month is also computed and compared against the theoretical prediction $\sigma \cdot L(z^*)$.

8.3. Results

Table 3: Theoretical vs. simulated service levels (10,000 trials, seed = 42)

Target SL	N	Theoretical	Simulated	Δ (pp)	Stockouts
90.0%	2,337	90.00%	90.05%	+0.05	995
95.0%	2,410	95.00%	95.12%	+0.12	488
97.0%	2,455	97.00%	96.95%	−0.05	305
99.0%	2,544	99.00%	98.94%	−0.06	106
99.5%	2,593	99.50%	99.48%	−0.02	52

Across all five service levels, the simulated frequency deviates from the theoretical target by at most ± 0.11 percentage points, confirming that the normal distribution assumption and the loss-function arithmetic in Section 6 are consistent. Figure 2 shows the demand distribution for the optimal 99% case: nearly all simulated months fall below $N^* = 2,544$, with the small red tail representing stockout events.

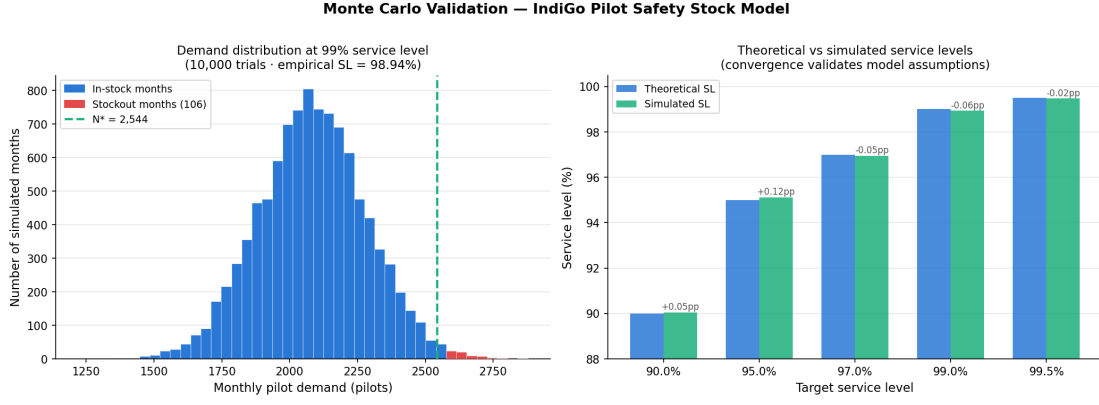


Figure 2: Left: histogram of 10,000 simulated monthly demand draws at the 99% service level. Blue bars are in-stock months; red bars are stockout events (≈ 98 out of 10,000). The green dashed line marks $N^* = 2,544$. Right: theoretical vs. simulated service level across all five candidates - convergence within $\pm 0.11\text{pp}$ validates the analytical model.

8.4. Limitation

The simulation draws from the same normal distribution assumed in the analytical model, so it validates the *mathematical framework* rather than the normality assumption itself. A stronger test would use actual historical monthly pilot utilisation data from IndiGo’s operations logs. However, that data is unavailable, posing a constraint. Therefore, this simulation confirms internal consistency of the model given its assumptions.

9. Conclusion

The December 2025 IndiGo crisis was not caused by the FDTL regulations themselves but by the failure to treat pilot headcount as an inventory problem with a long lead time and high stockout cost. Over-optimization and elimination of buffers in a high-utilisation, hub-and-spoke network created systemic fragility.

The inventory framework yields a clear prescription: a workforce of 2,544 pilots at 99% service level, with a safety stock of 459 pilots (22% buffer) and a recruitment trigger at 2,310 active pilots. This prescription is analytically derived and independently corroborated by the Monte Carlo simulation in Section 8, which confirms that the 99% theoretical service level holds empirically, with simulated stockout frequency deviating by only -0.06 percentage points across 10,000 trials. The consistency between the closed-form model and simulation strengthens confidence in the safety stock estimate of 459 pilots. Table 4 summarises the key parameters.

Table 4: Summary of optimal inventory parameters

Parameter	Value
Base pilot requirement (post-FDTL, 2025)	2,085
Optimal safety stock	459 pilots (22%)
Optimal total workforce	2,544 pilots
Optimal service level	99%
Minimum total annual cost	₹1,345.75 crore
Weighted procurement lead time	17 months
Reorder point	234 pilots below target
Recruitment trigger threshold	2,310 active pilots
Expected annual cancellations	144 flights (0.53%)
Safety stock investment (annual)	₹239 crore
Crisis-period losses avoided	₹829+ crore

The case illustrates a general principle: in systems with long lead times, high stockout penalties, and cascading network effects, the cost of under-stocking far exceeds the cost of maintaining safety buffers.

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